Chapter 22

Responsible Leadership: The Driving Force

THE RAPIDITY AND INCISIVENESS WITH WHICH CHANGES WERE BROUGHT about in Tihar had left everyone almost breathless, especially the prison staff itself. To a person, they had been willing or unwilling partners in the corruption and decadence that were rife in Tihar in the earlier years. To them it was almost as if a whirlwind of change had swept them off their feet. This incredible transformation cannot be attributed to anything other than charismatic leadership. Such leadership was essential for an institution like Tihar Jail, and it was very fortunate that the prison did get such leadership when it needed it the most.

At this stage, therefore, one is tempted to digress a bit, i.e., in order to enumerate those qualities that are essential for exhibiting such leadership.

The foremost is, naturally, an overpowering urge to make realistic commitments and fulfil them within a given time frame. Next comes the willingness to shoulder responsibility, without flinching, for actions taken on the courage of convictions.

The other qualities include the ability to create an open and honest environment wherein provisions are made for everyone's physical, emotional and spiritual well-being and the capacity to repose confidence and trust in the staff members that inspires them to keep themselves informed about the latest developments and also instils in them the trait of honestly admitting their own mistakes. This ensures loyalty and cohesion among all team members. Such a situation ensures a change in the mindset from merely obeying orders to acting on one's own initiative.

The courage to stand up for what is right, irrespective of what others may think, encourages confidence in the staff. The ability to act as a shock absorber between the staff and the powers that be, irrespective of the toll it takes in terms of stress and other psychological factors, ensures deep-rooted loyalty.

The proclivity and the ability to take decisions promptly and to ensure follow-up action forthwith are needed. The aptitude for articulating concepts, strategies and tactics concisely and forcefully is also important.

Enthusiasm for the accomplishment of the task at hand appears to be the driving force behind a sustainable leadership. It is this trait that ensures performance to the best of one's ability and inspires others almost contagiously.

Taking the initiative appears as much the hallmark of the leader as is his or her ability to inspire subordinates to develop this quality. Close contact with good leadership will almost invariably inspire similar qualities and it is this factor that ensures the continued performance of a task even in the leader's absence.

Integrity, of course, is an essential characteristic, which is non-negotiable. Truth occupies a